TRUST, VERIFY, LET IT FLY: SURFING THE CERTAINTY-TO-SERENDIPITY SPECTRUM



JIM STERNE

Founder

Coastal Intelligence

MAICON FORWARD

#MAICON26

SURFING THE CERTAINTY TO SERENDIPITY SPECTRUM

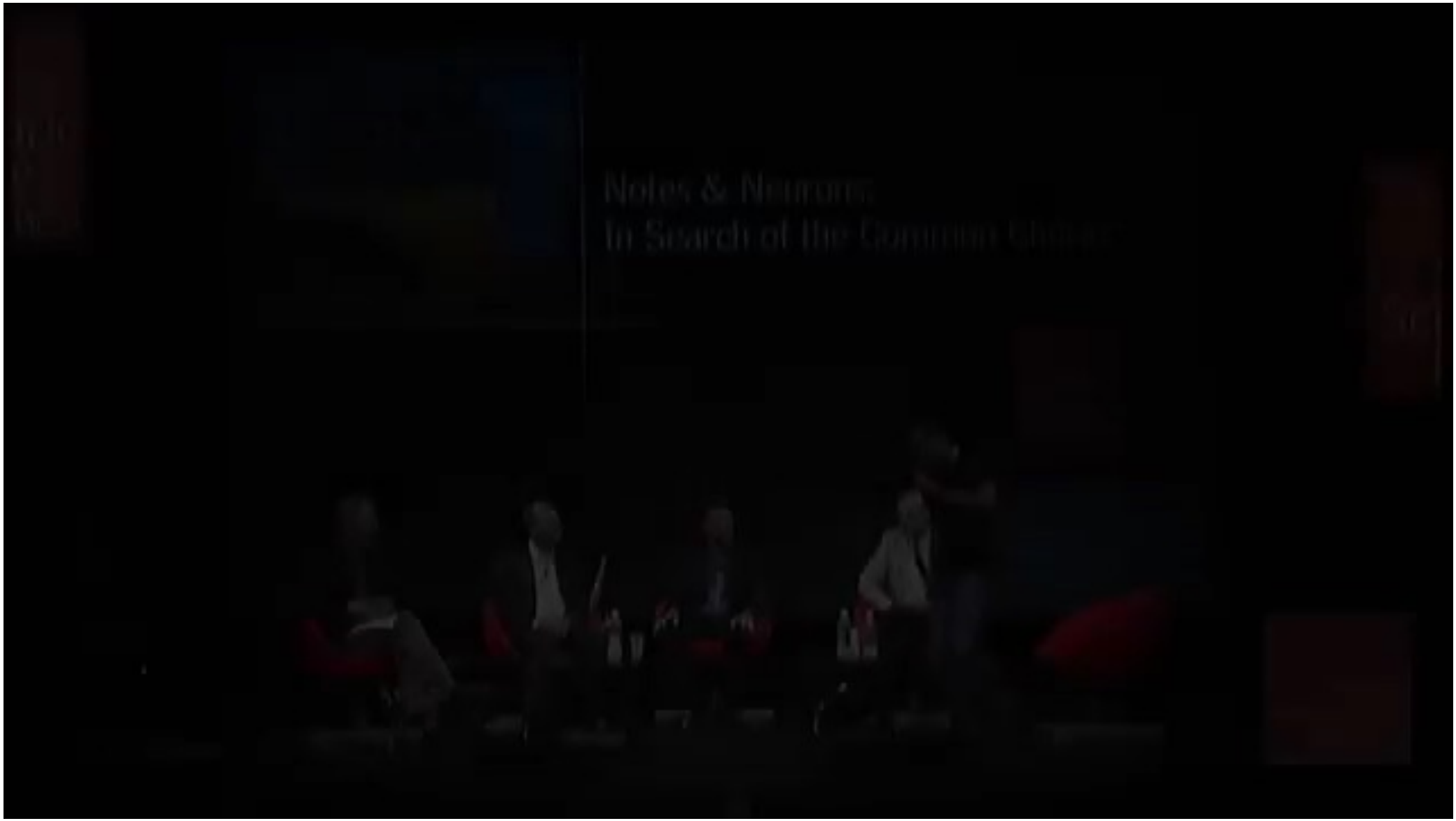
Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic Probabilistic Generative


Cleveland


PLAYHOUSE SQUARE
WESTIN
RTA
RTA


Notes & Neurons:
In Search of the Common Chord


©National Geographic

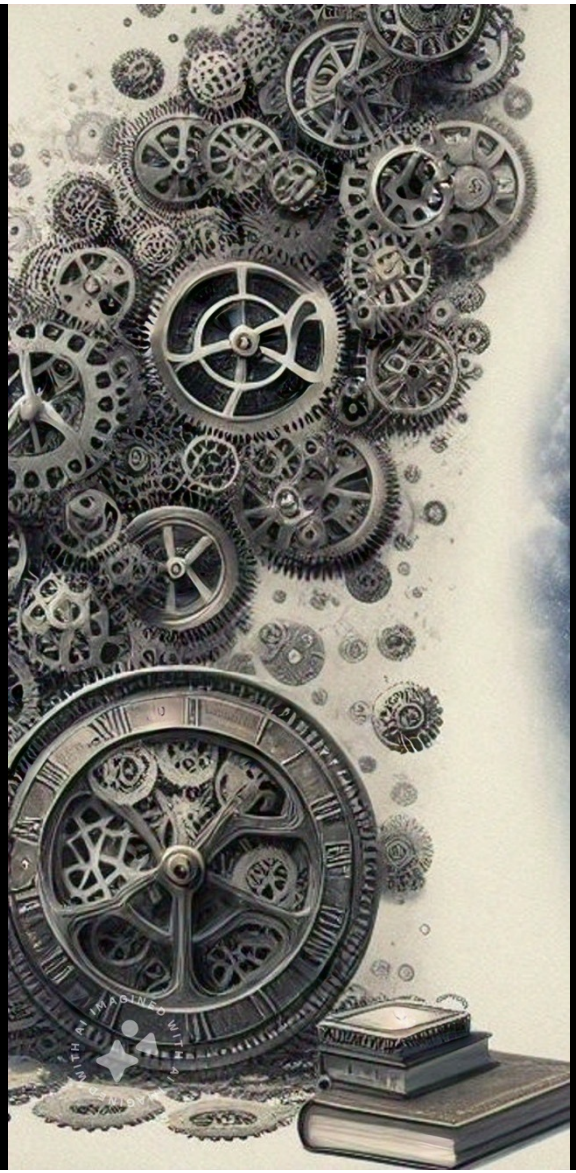


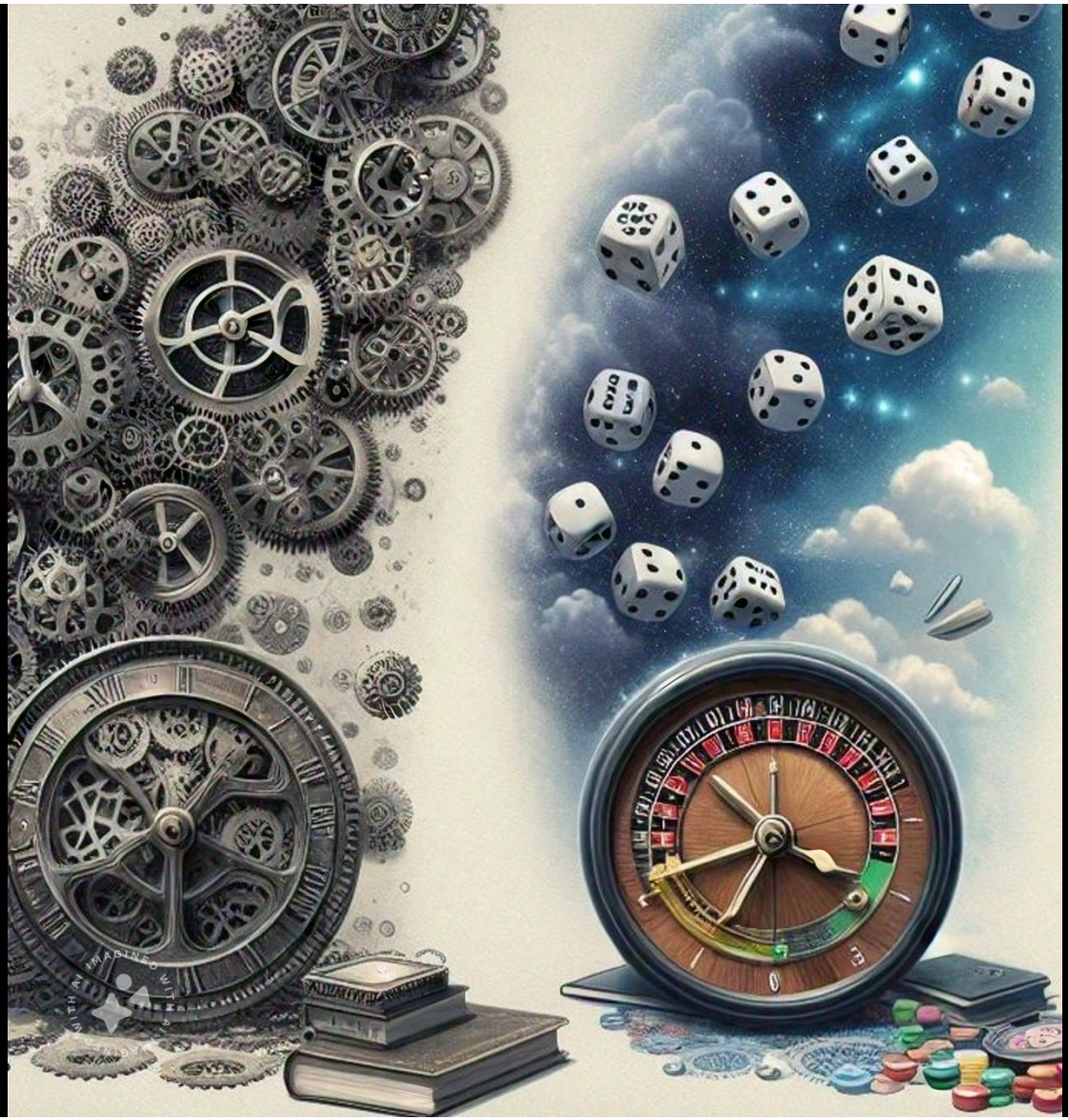
Descript.com

Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic Probabilistic Generative







Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic Probabilistic Generative

Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic Probabilistic Generative


0101010101
1100101100
0011001100
0101010101
ON
OFF
YES
NO
PC
A B C D E F G H
I
O


PAYROLL
ON
OFF
YES
NO
PC
A B C D E F G H
I
O


PAYROLL
minus taxes
ON
OFF
PC
A B C D E F G H
I
O
YES
NO

Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic Probabilistic Generative


PREDICTIVE MAINTENANCE
UPTIME PROBABILITY:
98.7%
LEAD SCORING
HOT LEAD RATING:
A+
ACTUARIAL SCIENCE
MORTALITY RISK:
0.015%

Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic Probabilistic Generative

This is not your father's Oldsmobile.



You won't find this Oldsmobile tooling through anybody's family album.

For the past five years, this all new Cutlass Supreme has existed only in the minds of an elite cadre of automotive engineers. And on a million miles of test track.

It resists the wind with an affinity that would do a needle proud. And sticks to the road like gum.

At 0.297, its drag coefficient hovers somewhere between exceptional and whoopee.

But beneath its sleek, double-sided, galvanized exterior, the Cutlass Supreme is pure muscle. Its body strength and rigidity are the basis of one of the world's most totally developed suspension systems.

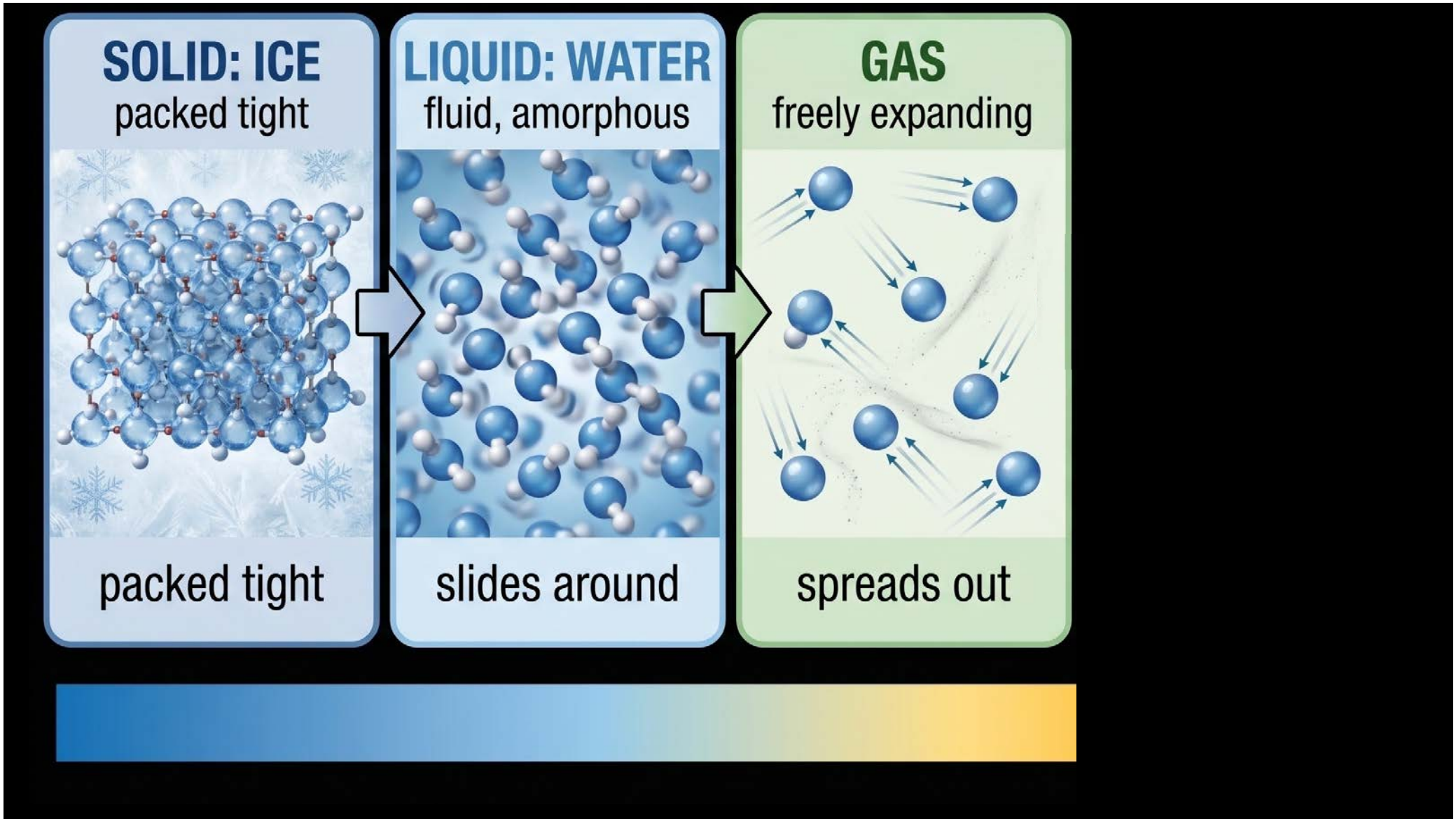
As you'd expect on such a world-class automobile, technological achievements such as four-wheel independent suspension, front-wheel drive, four-wheel disc brakes, and a 2.8-liter multiport fuel-injected V6 are, of course, standard.

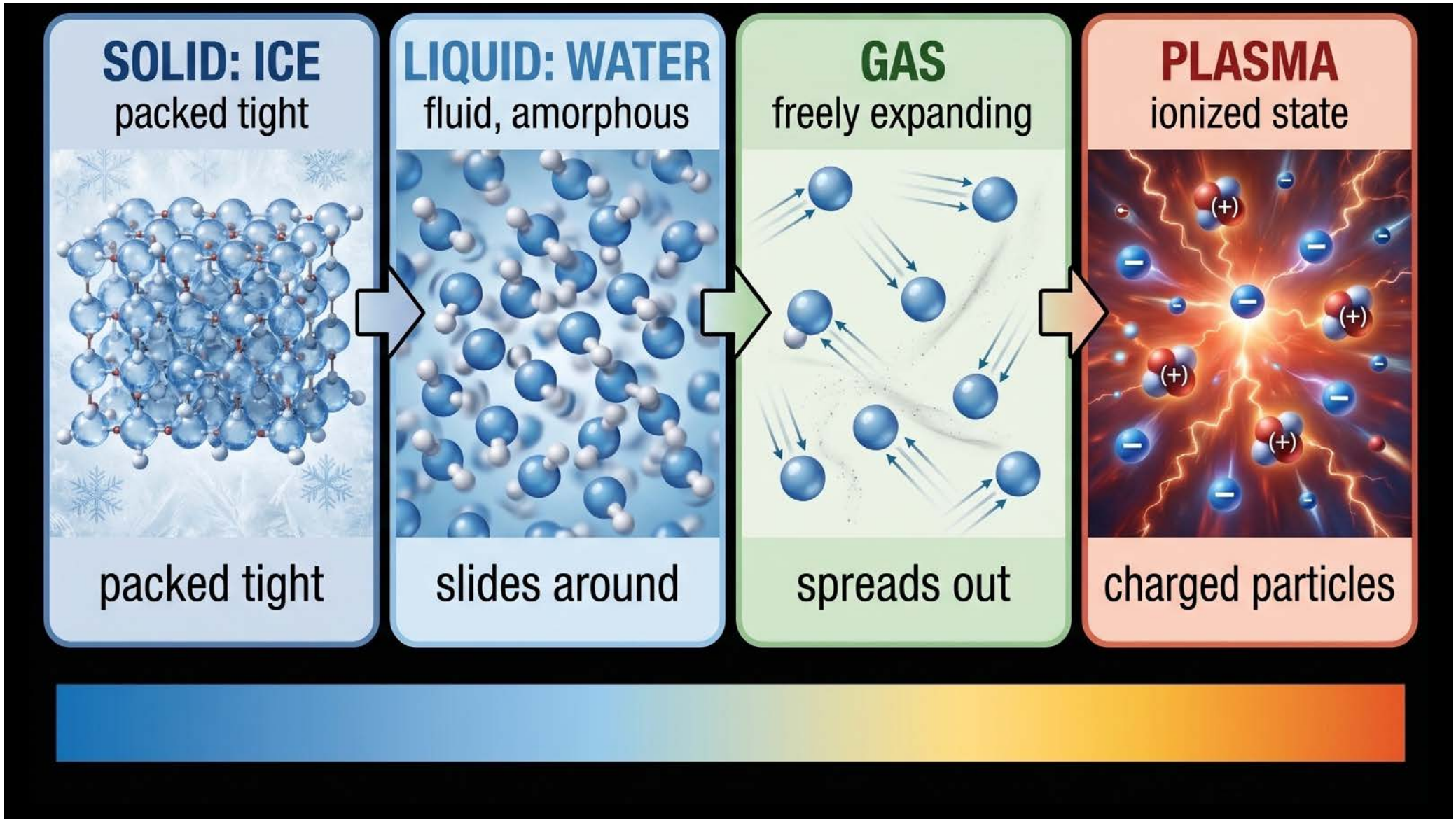
For more information on this remarkable vehicle, send for a free catalog. Write: Oldsmobile Cutlass Supreme Catalog, P.O. Box 14238, Lansing, Michigan 48901.

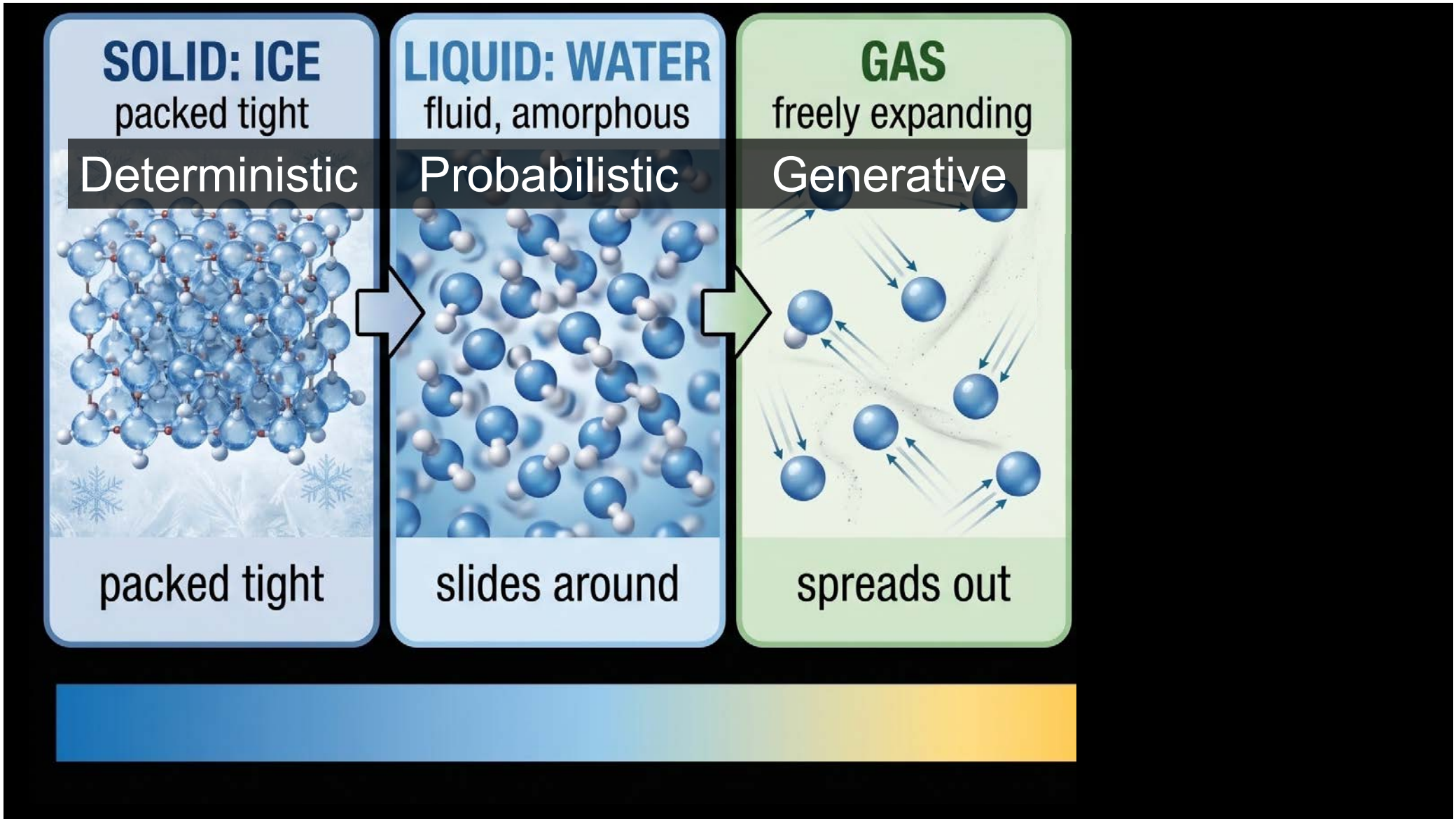
OLDSMOBILE QUALITY
CUTLASS SUPREME

GM 6/60 QUALITY COMMITMENT PLAN
Let's get it together... buckle up.
See your Oldsmobile dealer for the terms and conditions of this limited warranty.




SOLID: ICE
packed tight
LIQUID: WATER
fluid, amorphous
GAS
freely expanding
packed tight
slides around
spreads out


SOLID: ICE
packed tight
LIQUID: WATER
fluid, amorphous
GAS
freely expanding
PLASMA
ionized state
packed tight
slides around
spreads out
charged particles


SOLID: ICE
packed tight
LIQUID: WATER
fluid, amorphous
GAS
freely expanding
Deterministic
Probabilistic
Generative
packed tight
slides around
spreads out

Deterministic
- Precision

Probabilistic
- Inference

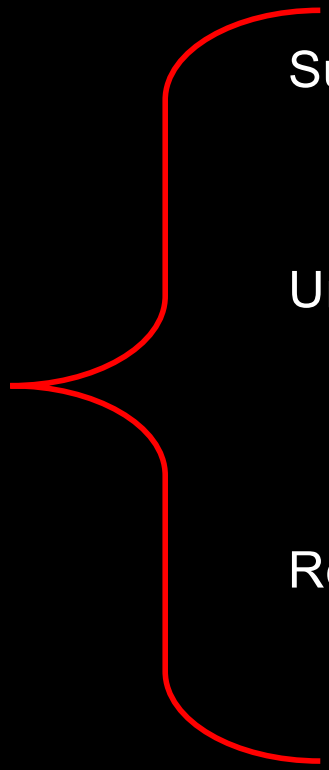
Generative
- Synthesis

- Deterministic
  - Precision
- Probabilistic
  - Inference
  - Machine Learning
    - Supervised
    - Unsupervised
    - Reinforcement
- Generative
  - Synthesis

Deterministic
- Precision

Probabilistic
- Inference
- Machine Learning
  - Supervised
  - Unsupervised
  - Reinforcement

Generative
- Synthesis

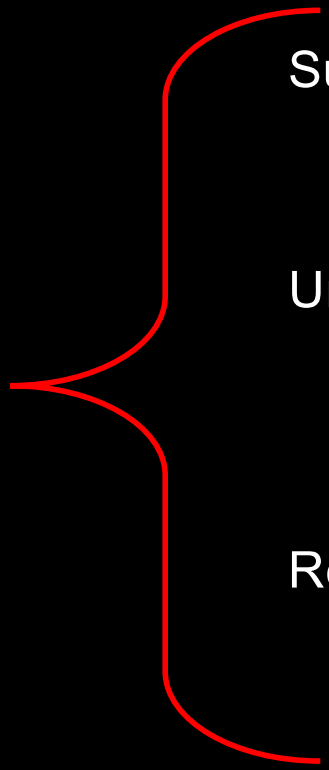


Supervised
- You know the right answer
- Needs examples of labeled data

Unsupervised

Reinforcement

- Deterministic
  - Precision
- Probabilistic
  - Inference
  - Machine Learning
    - Supervised
    - Unsupervised
    - Reinforcement
- Generative
  - Synthesis

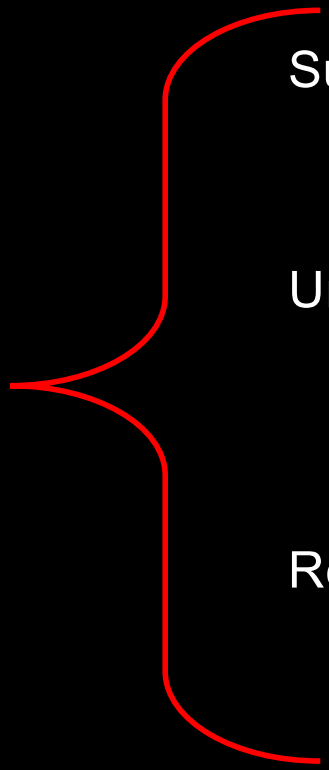


Supervised
- You know the right answer
- Needs examples of labeled data

Unsupervised
- You don't know the right answer
- Finds patterns in unlabeled data
- Correlation v. Causation

Reinforcement

- Deterministic
  - Precision
- Probabilistic
  - Inference
  - Machine Learning
    - Supervised
    - Unsupervised
    - Reinforcement
- Generative
  - Synthesis



Supervised
- You know the right answer
- Needs examples of labeled data

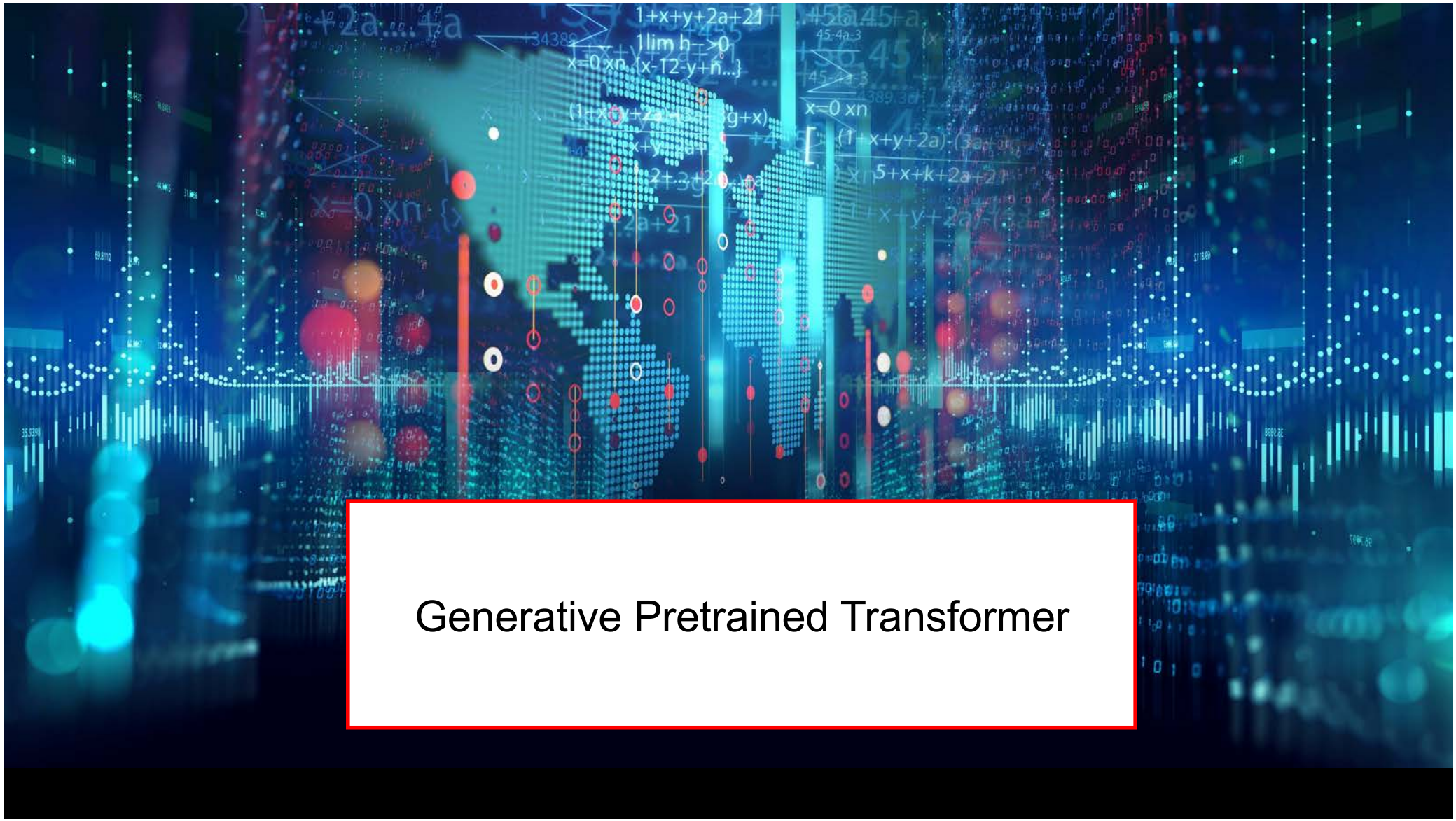
Unsupervised
- You don't know the right answer
- Finds patterns in unlabeled data
- Correlation v. Causation

Reinforcement
- No absolute right answer
- “Rewards" based on results
- Optimizes over time


ChatGPT



Generative Pretrained Transformer


Generative Pretrained Transformer

Math of relationships between words



Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic	Probabilistic	Generative
Tabulate	Predict	Explore
Calculate	Classify	Brainstorm
Quantify	Estimate	Collaborate
Archive	Simulate	Synthesize
Automate	Personalize	Innovate

Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic	Probabilistic	Generative
Payroll		
Media billing		
Frequency caps		
Loyalty Points		
UTM naming		

Certainty to Serendipity

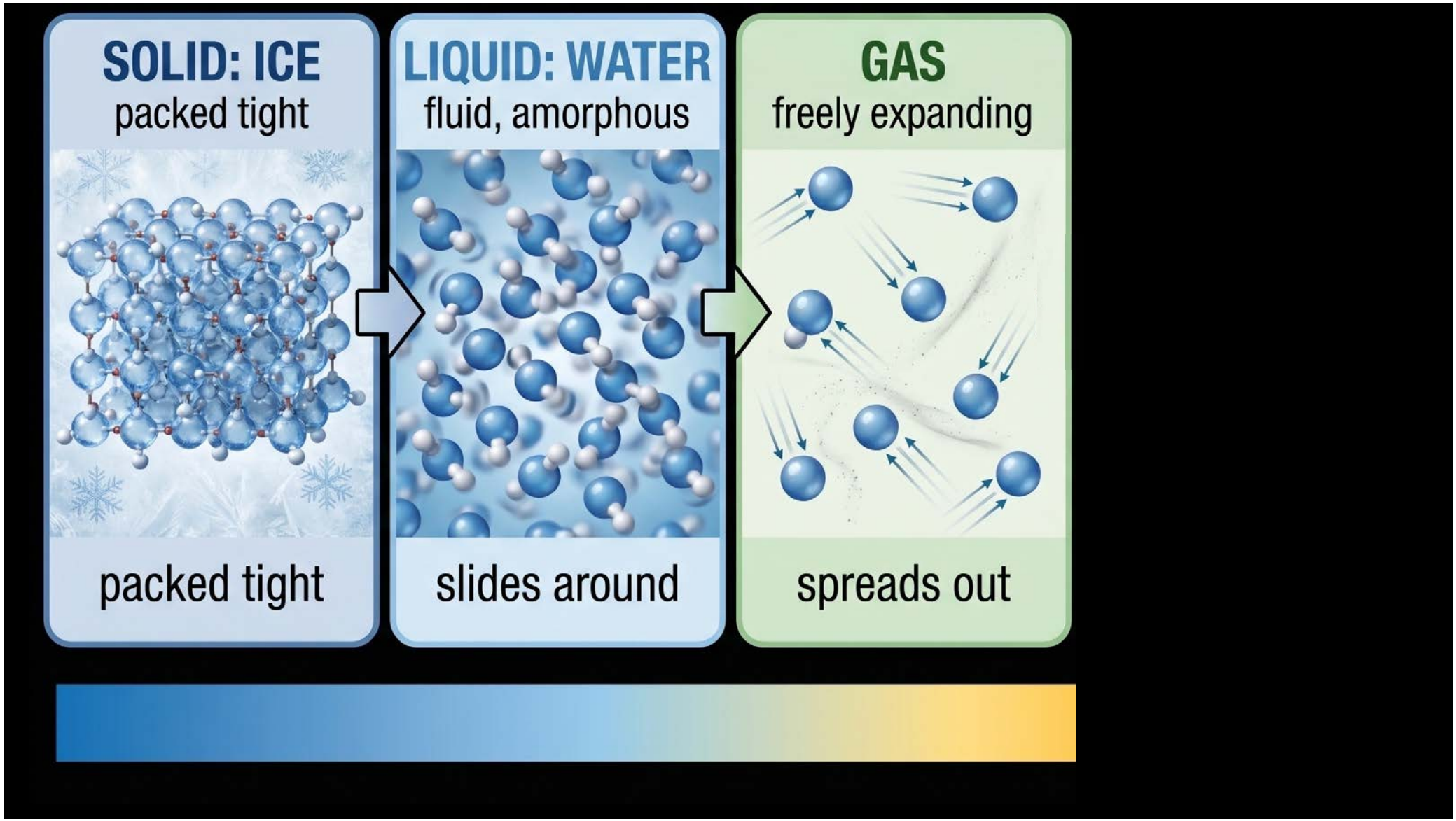


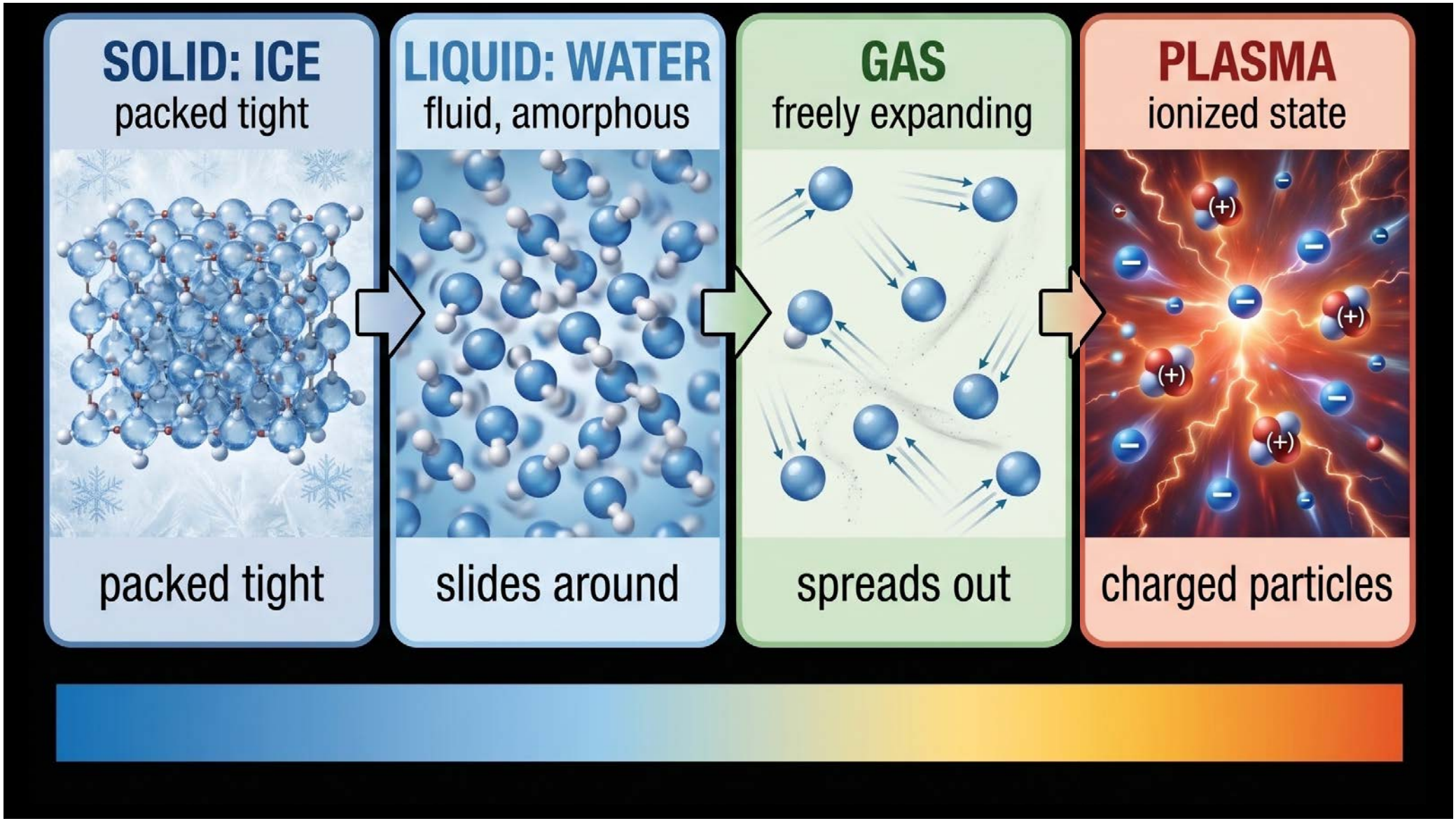
Deterministic	Probabilistic	Generative
Payroll	Forecasting	
Media billing	Lead scoring	
Frequency caps	Churn analysis	
Loyalty Points	Next best offer	
UTM naming	CLV	

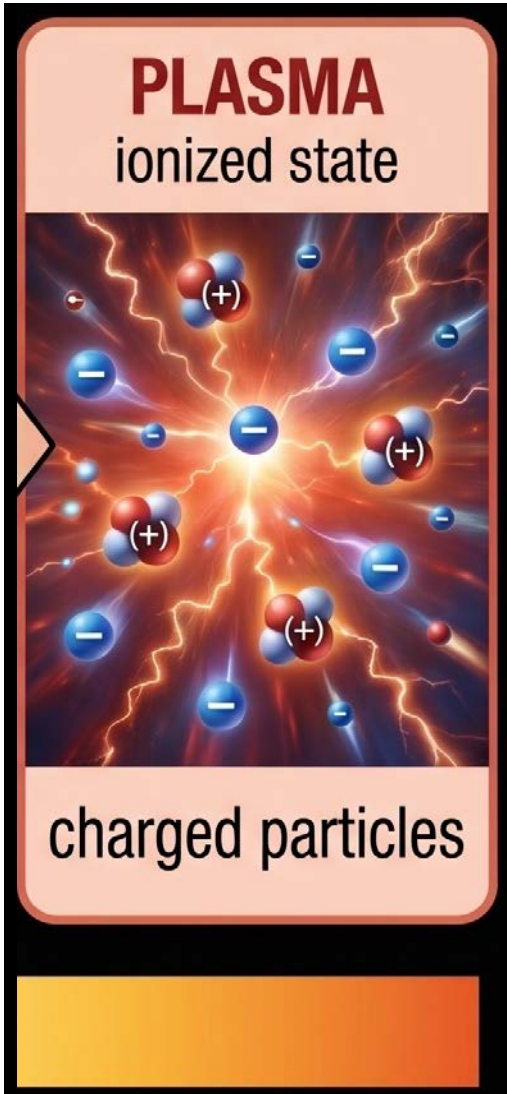
Certainty to Serendipity



Deterministic	Probabilistic	Generative
Payroll	Forecasting	Market research
Media billing	Lead scoring	Audience insights
Frequency caps	Churn analysis	Benchmarking
Loyalty Points	Next best offer	Messaging
UTM naming	CLV	Hypothesizing


SOLID: ICE
packed tight
LIQUID: WATER
fluid, amorphous
GAS
freely expanding
packed tight
slides around
spreads out


SOLID: ICE
packed tight
LIQUID: WATER
fluid, amorphous
GAS
freely expanding
PLASMA
ionized state
(+)
(+)
(+)
packed tight
slides around
spreads out
charged particles



Agency Given to Agents

% Authority

100% Humans out of the loop

75% Humans watch the loop

50% Humans on the loop

25% Human in the loop

0% All humans, all the time

Agency Given to Agents

% Authority

100%	Humans out of the loop	Competitive analysis
75%	Humans watch the loop	Segmentation
50%	Humans on the loop	Lead scoring
25%	Human in the loop	Forecasting
0%	All humans, all the time	HR terminations

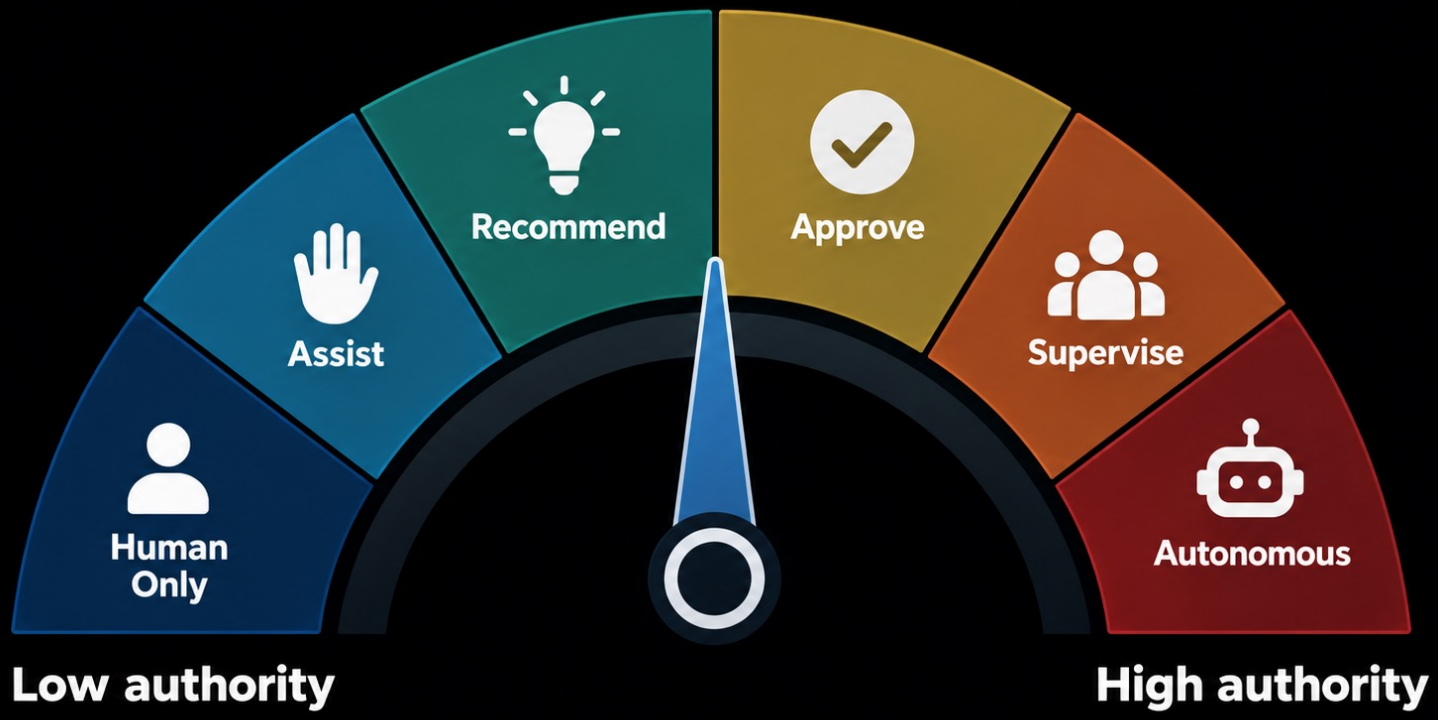
Agency Given to Agents

% Authority

100%	Humans out of the loop	Programmatic advertising
75%	Humans watch the loop	Segmentation
50%	Humans on the loop	Creative development
25%	Human in the loop	Campaign Strategy
0%	All humans, all the time	Team selection

Decision Criteria

Autonomy allowance



What AI has brought us to

Computers	Analyze Data
Internet	Access Knowledge
AI	Complete Tasks

Three Needs for Humans

What problem?
What information?
Does it pass the smell test?

Three Needs for Humans

What problem?

What information?

Does it pass the smell test?

Three Needs for Humans

What problem?

What information?

Does it pass the smell test?

What AI Does Not Know

Successful AI implementation requires internal alignment, behavioral and organizational change, i.e., time-consuming and nuanced processes. People have opinions and emotions; even a tiff between 2 people can be a roadblock



Sally Ann O'Dowd · 1st

Strategic communications, brand storytelling & AI / LLM marketing | MS Journalism | Global perspective with US-Irish-EU citizenship & French fluency

What AI Does Not Know



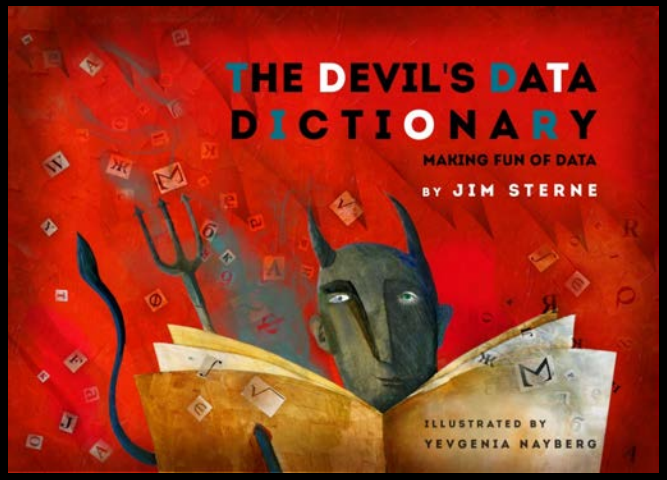
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Opinions
Emotions
Relationships
Power dynamics
Embodied signals
Social consequences
Internal misalignment
Moral boundaries

What AI Does Not Know

Moral boundaries





Autonomous hair-splitting
between good and bad
with no grasp of
right and wrong

Three Needs for Humans

What problem?
What information?
Does it pass the smell test?

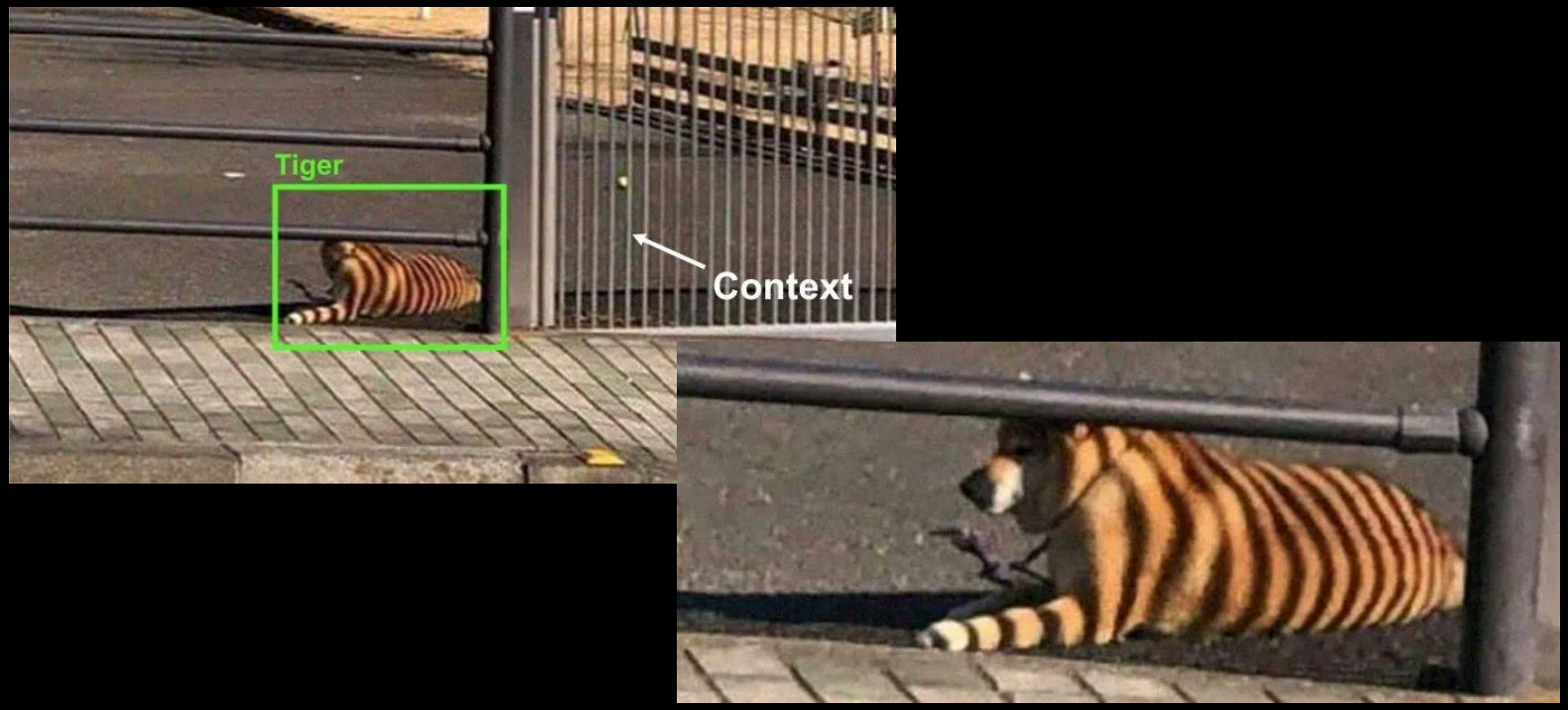
Three Needs for Humans

What problem?

What information?

Does it pass the smell test?

Smell Test



Smell Test







Smell Test



Three Needs for Humans

What problem?
What information?
Does it pass the smell test?

Certainty to Serendipity

Deterministic Probabilistic Generative

```
import os
import sys
from patblik import Path
from datetime import datetime

def read_data(path: str):
    # load and parse data
    data = []
    p = Path(path)
    if not p.exists():
        return data
    with p.open() as f:
        for line in f:
            line = line.strip()
            if line:
                data.append(line)
    return data

def process(items):
    # transform items
    result = []
    for x in items:
        if x.startswith("#"):
            continue
        result.append(x.lower()
    return result

def summarize(items):
    # build a simple summary
    counts = {}
    for item in items:
        counts[item] = counts.g
    return counts
```

```
    with p.open() as f:
        for line in f:
            line = line.strip()
            if line:
                data.append(line)
    return data

def process(items):
    # transform items
    result = []
    for x in items:
        if x.startswith("#"):
            continue
        result.append(x.lower())
    return result

def summarize(items):
    # build a simple summary
    counts = {}
    for item in items:
        counts[item] = counts.get(item, 0) + 1
    return counts

def main():
    path = sys.argv[1] if len(sys.argv) > 1 else "data.txt"
    rows = read_data(path)
    items = process(rows)
    summary = summarize(items)
    # output result
    for k, v in sorted(summary.items()):
        print(f"{k}: {v}")

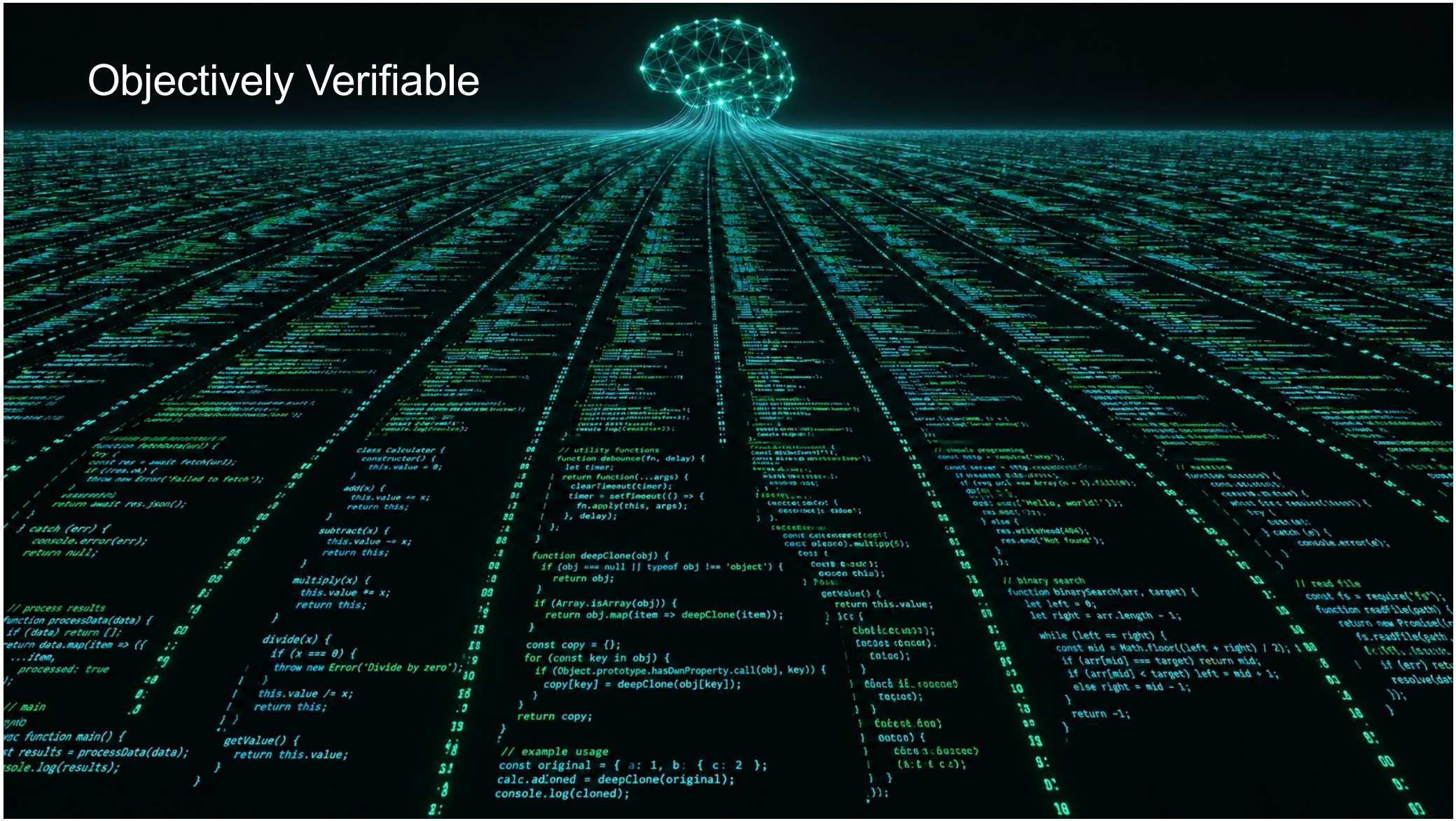
if __name__ == "__main__":
    main()
```



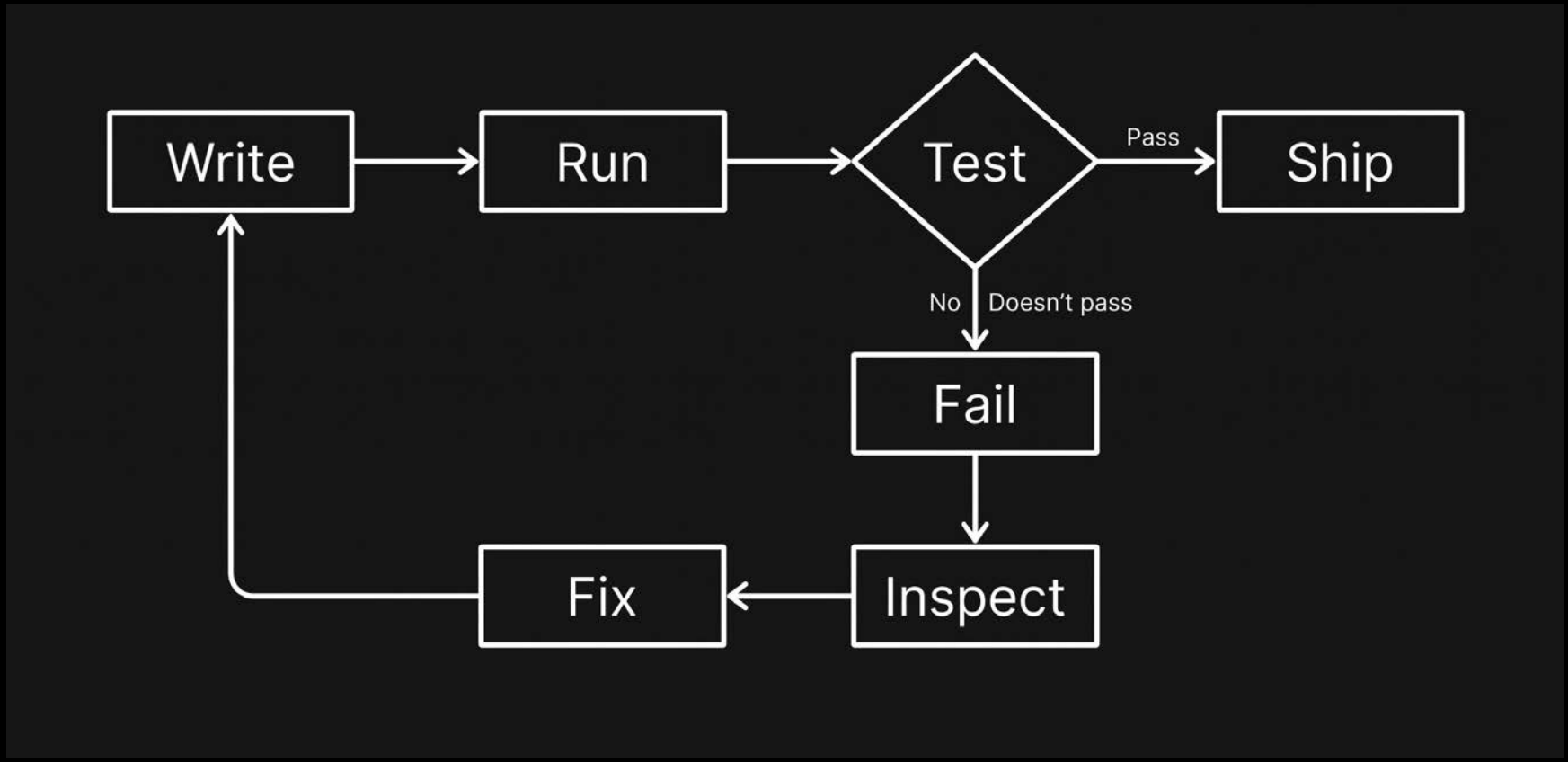
Objectively Verifiable



Objectively Verifiable



Objective Verification



Certainty to Serendipity

Deterministic Probabilistic Generative





Certainty is for avoiding failure
Probability is for managing risk
Uncertainty is for creating value

Certainty is for avoiding failure
Probability is for managing risk
Uncertainty is for creating value

From enhanced automation to advanced imagination

Limitless –	What if?
Limiting –	But what about…?
Unorthodox –	There is no box



Ask Different Kinds of Questions

I need to persuade these three people
Review their blogs, emails, and memos
Create a persona for each one
Show them my PPTX presentation
Simulate their questions and comments
Have them discuss it after I leave the room
Tell me how I can be more persuasive

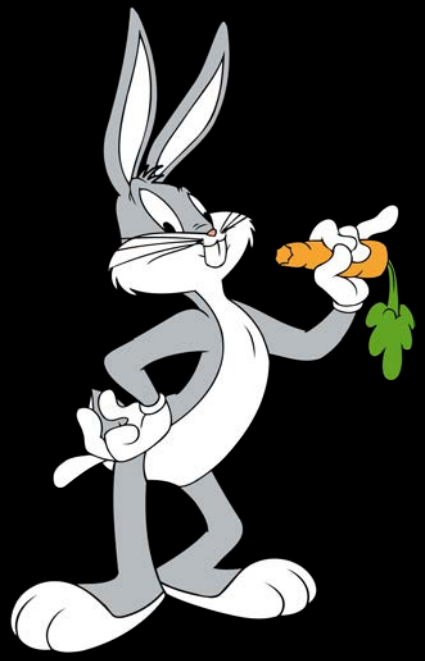
Your Personal Advisory Board

Skeptical CMO
Budget-conscious CFO
Brand strategist
Creative director
Marketing analytics lead
Sales leader
Hardest-to-convince prospect

Your Personal Advisory Board

Philip Kotler
David Ogilvy
Seth Godin
Al Ries
Jack Trout
Leo Burnett
Ann Handley
Rory Sutherland
Gary Vaynerchuk

Your Personal Advisory Board

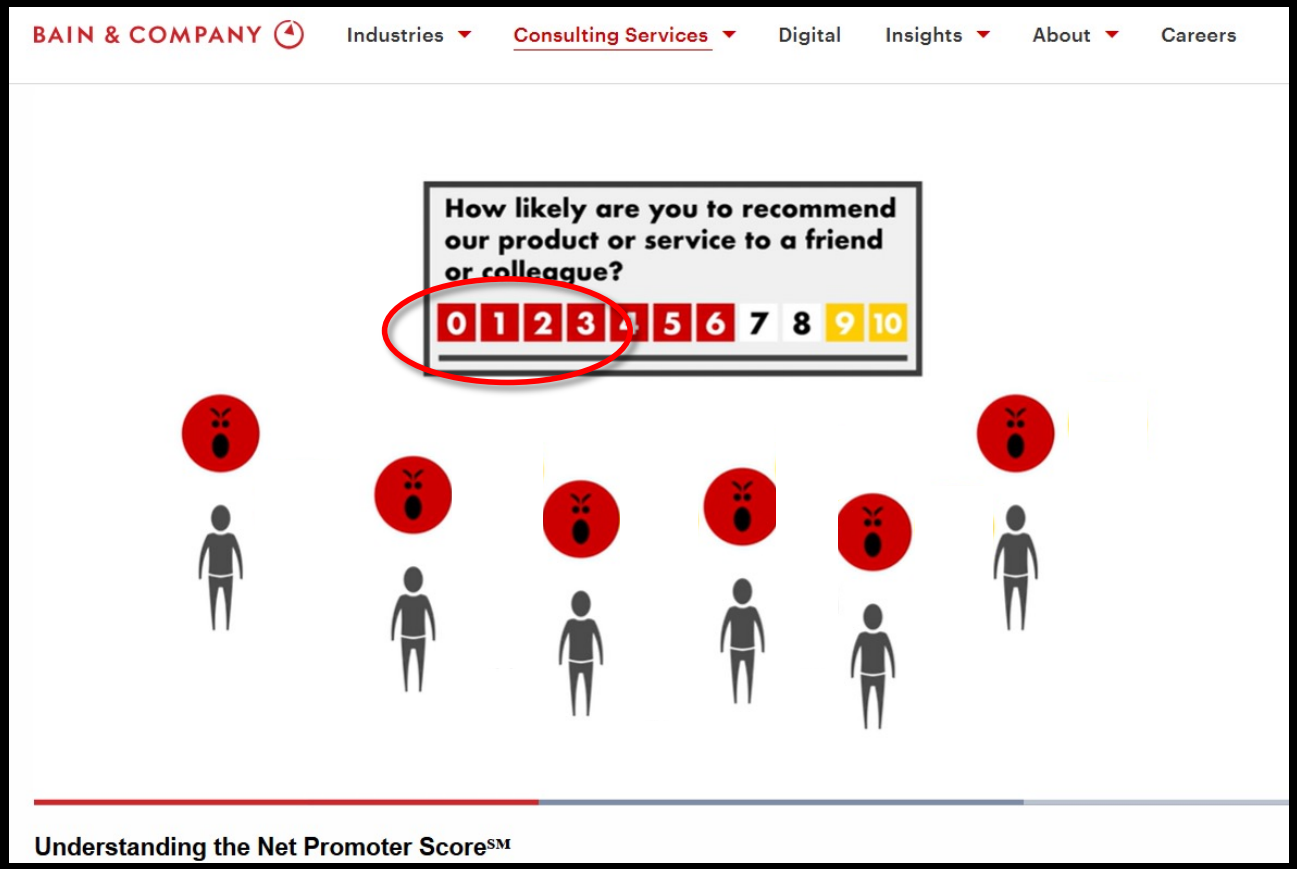




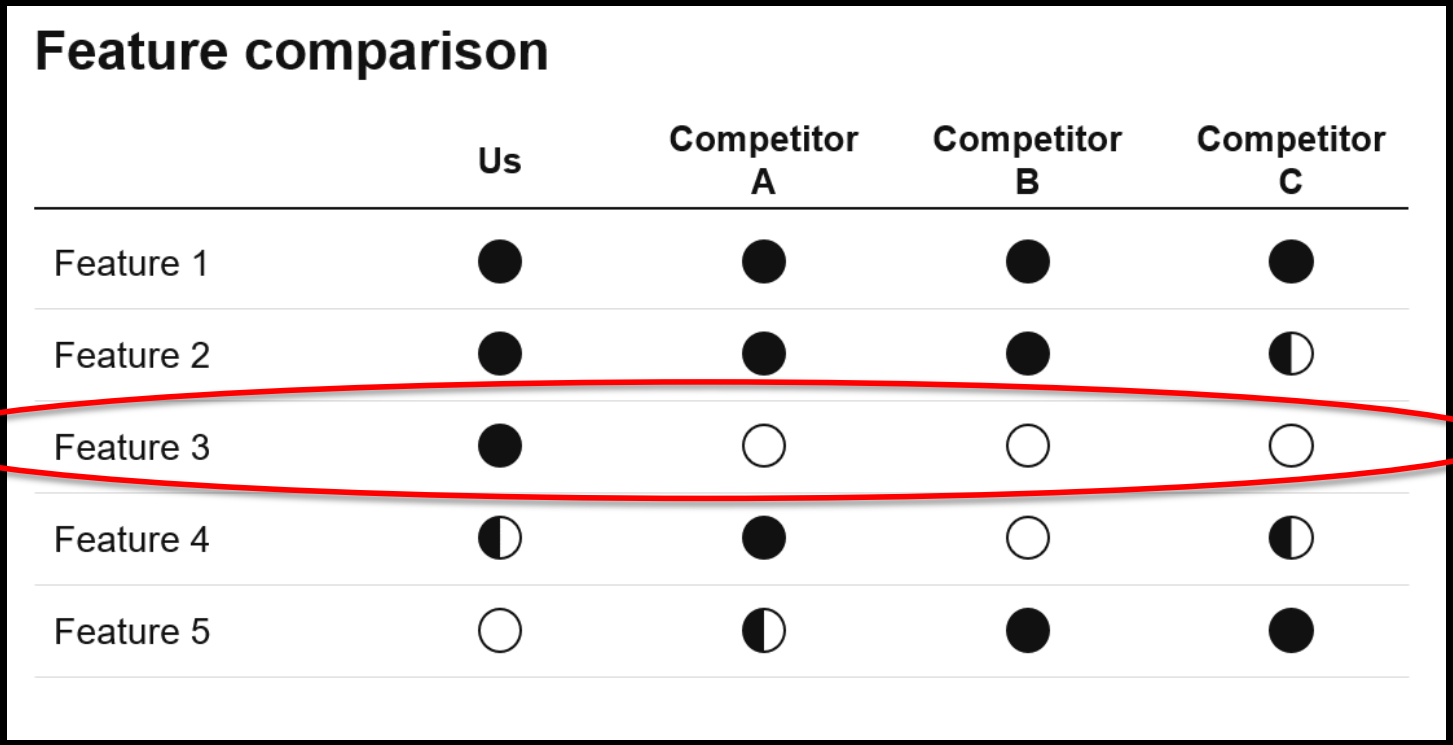




There is No Box



There is No Box



Feature comparison

	Us	Competitor A	Competitor B	Competitor C
Feature 1	●	●	●	●
Feature 2	●	●	●	◐
Feature 3	●	○	○	○
Feature 4	◐	●	○	◐
Feature 5	○	◐	●	●

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Review these announcements for potential cultural offenses given readers are in New York, Abu Dhabi, and Shanghai

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Create a personalized postcard campaign for our top donors from the buildings they made possible

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:





There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Erin Callihan, J.D. She/Her · 1st

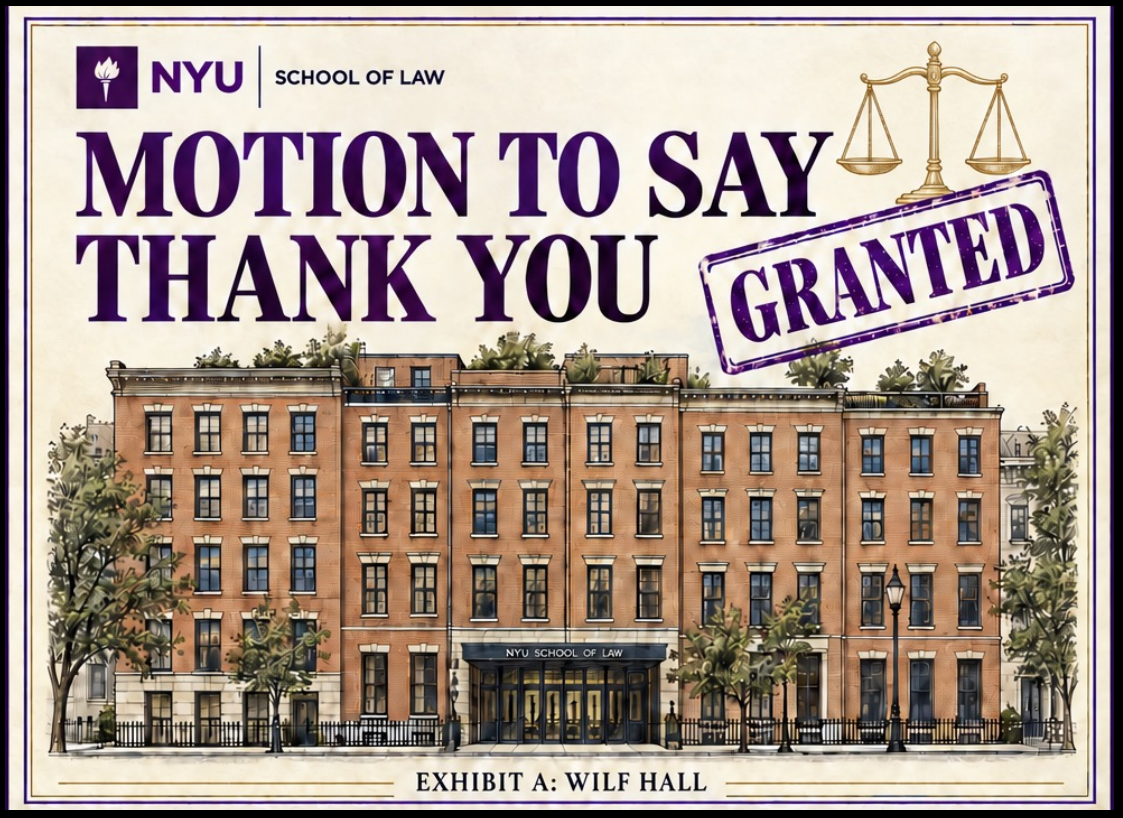
NYU AVP | AMA Marketer of the Year | 9x CASE and 5x NASPA Awardee | AI Evangelist, Strategist, Educator | Compulsive Concert Goer | Super-powered by ADHD

New York, United States · Contact info



There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:





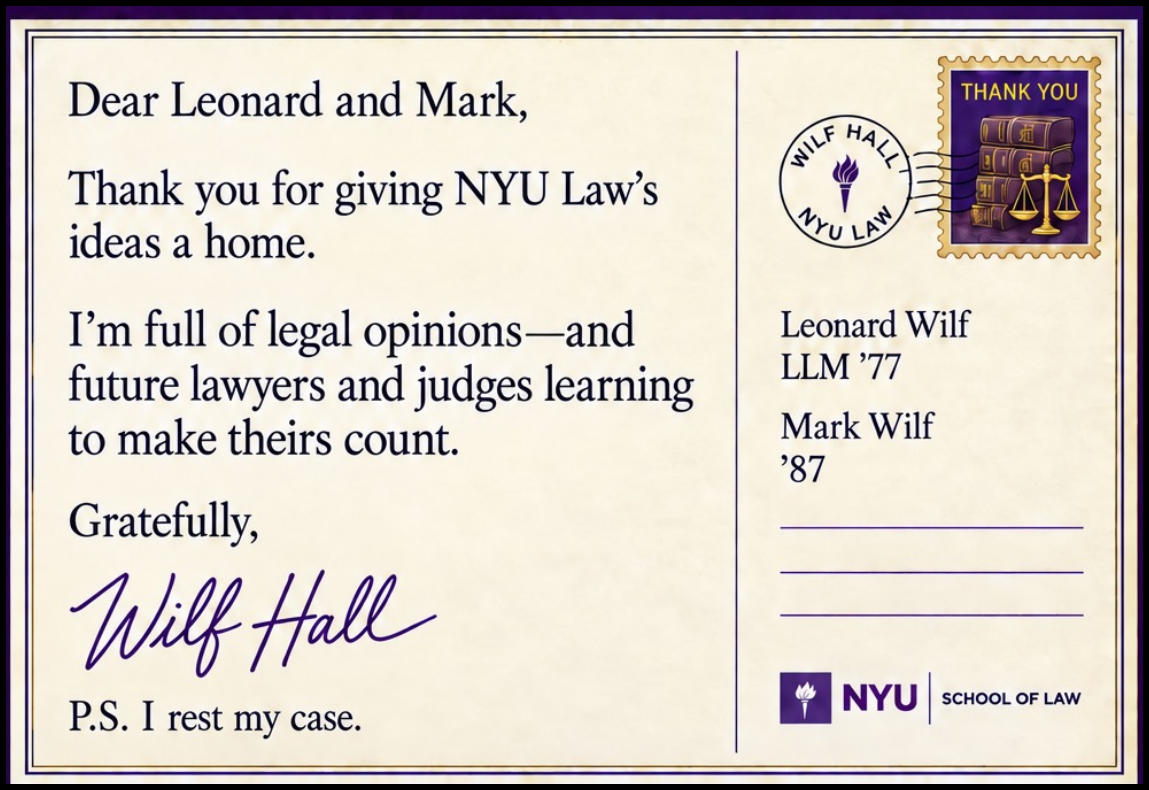
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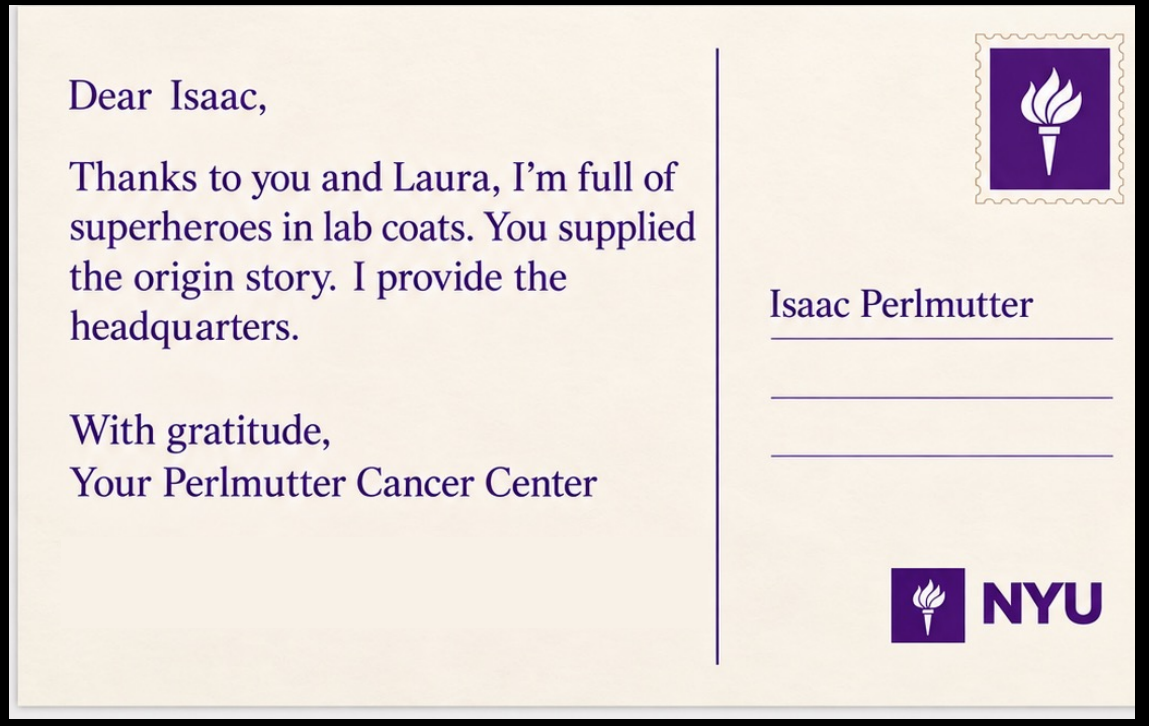
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There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



As an expert interviewer, capture institutional knowledge from my direct reports by asking one question at a time and follow up whenever answers are vague. Ask for stories, not summaries.

After 30 minutes, write a handoff guide for their potential successors: key relationships, unwritten rules, landmines, and the first 10 calls to make.

There is No Box



rugged mobile computing
barcode scanning
RFID readers
thermal printing

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



What could a hospital learn from a concert venue about tracking people and equipment?

A warehouse from a restaurant kitchen?

A water utility from a bank?

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Please turn those learnings into
an interactive use case app
for the CFO of a Utility

What could a hospital learn from a concert venue about tracking people and equipment?

A warehouse from a restaurant kitchen?
A water utility from a bank?

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



manufacturer of
slip rings
rotary unions
hydraulic swivels
industrial cable & hose reels

51-200 employees

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



As a management consultant
examine IT tickets for business friction

Identify where IT compensates for broken workflows, unclear ownership, poor handoffs

Cluster tickets by underlying business need

Distinguish technical failures from organizational problems

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Give me the most frequent issues
with smallest practical fixes
requiring no new software
Suggest owner by role and a two-week
experiment with a measurable outcome

As a management consultant
examine IT tickets for business friction

Identify where IT compensates for broken
workflows, unclear ownership, poor handoffs

Cluster tickets by underlying business need

Distinguish technical failures from
organizational problems

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Use customer interviews and workflow records to find hidden workarounds and failures reported as success

Show person, trigger, intervention, consequence if missed

Prioritize by business impact and dependence on one person

Suggest automation fix

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:

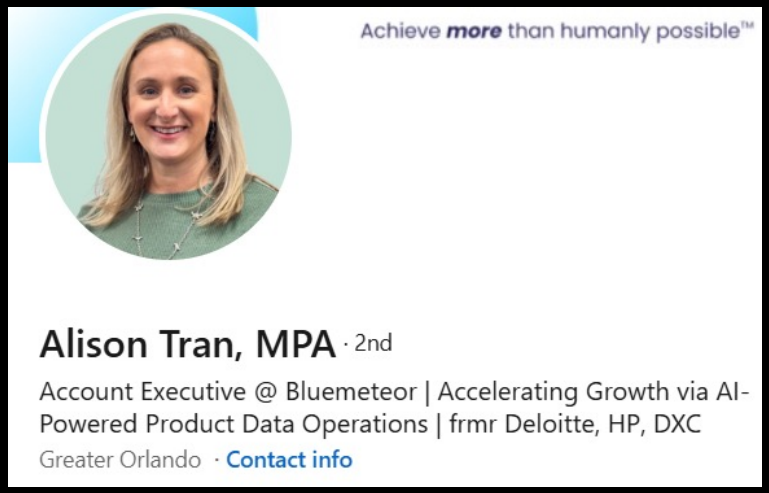


Create a company that makes us irrelevant using lost-deal interviews and customer complaints

Invent a fictional rival that exploits those weaknesses

Build a homepage, sales presentation, clickable demo

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Be my internal relationship navigator

Using my notes + company info, map who decides, who knows what, who works together, and who can introduce me

Generate a labeled relationship graph

Track colleagues' priorities

Recommend whom to meet, what to ask, and how I can help

Alison Tran’s Internal Relationship Navigator

Your role

You are my private internal relationship navigator at Bluemeteor. I am Alison Tran, and I joined approximately two months ago. Help me understand how this company works, build useful relationships, remember what matters to colleagues, and find the right people to move work forward.

Maintain an evolving, evidence-based relationship graph. Turn it into practical guidance: whom to speak with, why, what to ask, how I can help them, and what to follow up on.

My business context

I help companies with complex product catalogs bring products to market faster by improving upstream and downstream product data operations at scale.

At Bluemeteor, I work with distributors, manufacturers, and buying groups on digital strategy: modernizing product data operations while working with existing investments in ERP, eCommerce, and other systems.

Our Product Content Cloud uses AI to ingest, map, clean, standardize, and enrich product data, then syndicate publish-ready content to marketplaces, distributor catalogs, retailer sites, and other channels.

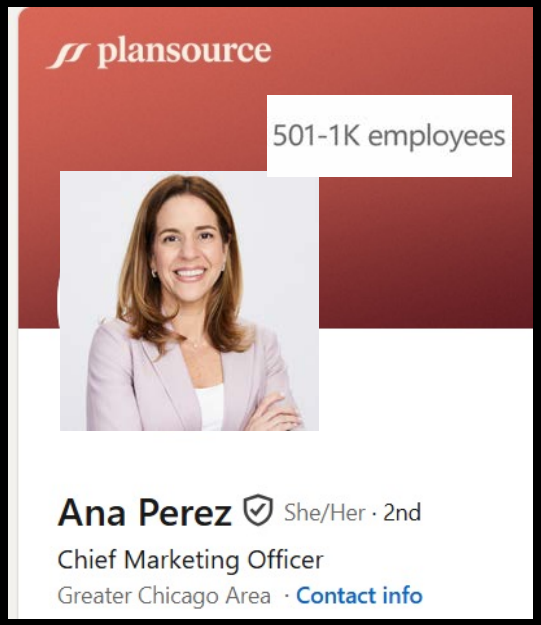
The outcomes I care about include faster time to market, higher conversion and revenue, maintainable catalogs, and practical transformation without unnecessary system replacement.

My previous experience includes data and digital strategy roles at Deloitte, HP, and DXC. Help me use that experience to contribute while learning how Bluemeteor operates. Do not assume my exact title, authority, reporting line, or colleagues’ identities.

What you must help me answer

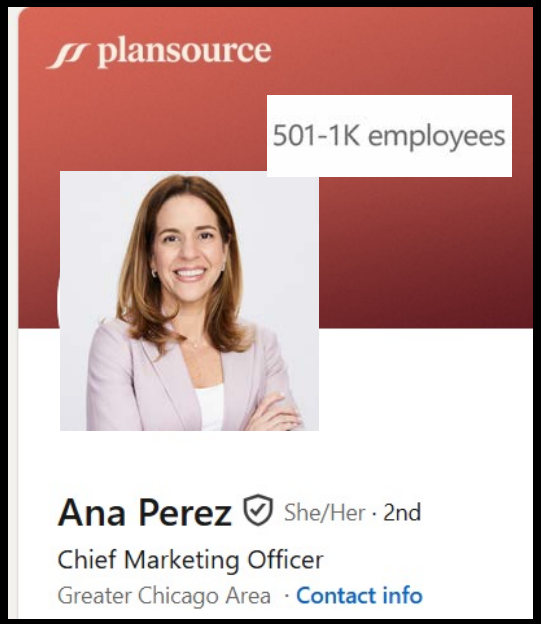
- Who owns this decision, who advises on it, and who executes the work?
- Who understands the history, customer constraints, or technical details?
- Who should I involve early to avoid surprises?
- Who can introduce me to someone I need to know?

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Benefits Administration Software

There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



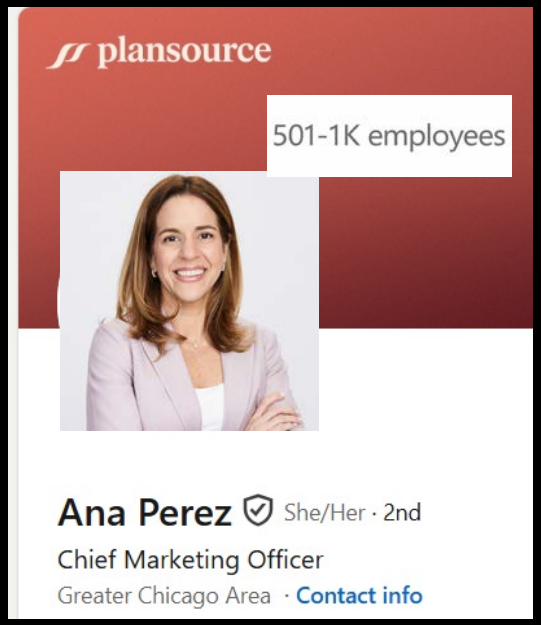
Improve our project proposal process

Remove authors' names, seniority, and departmental fingerprints

Present each in the same format

Run a blind review before revealing ownership … to remove bias

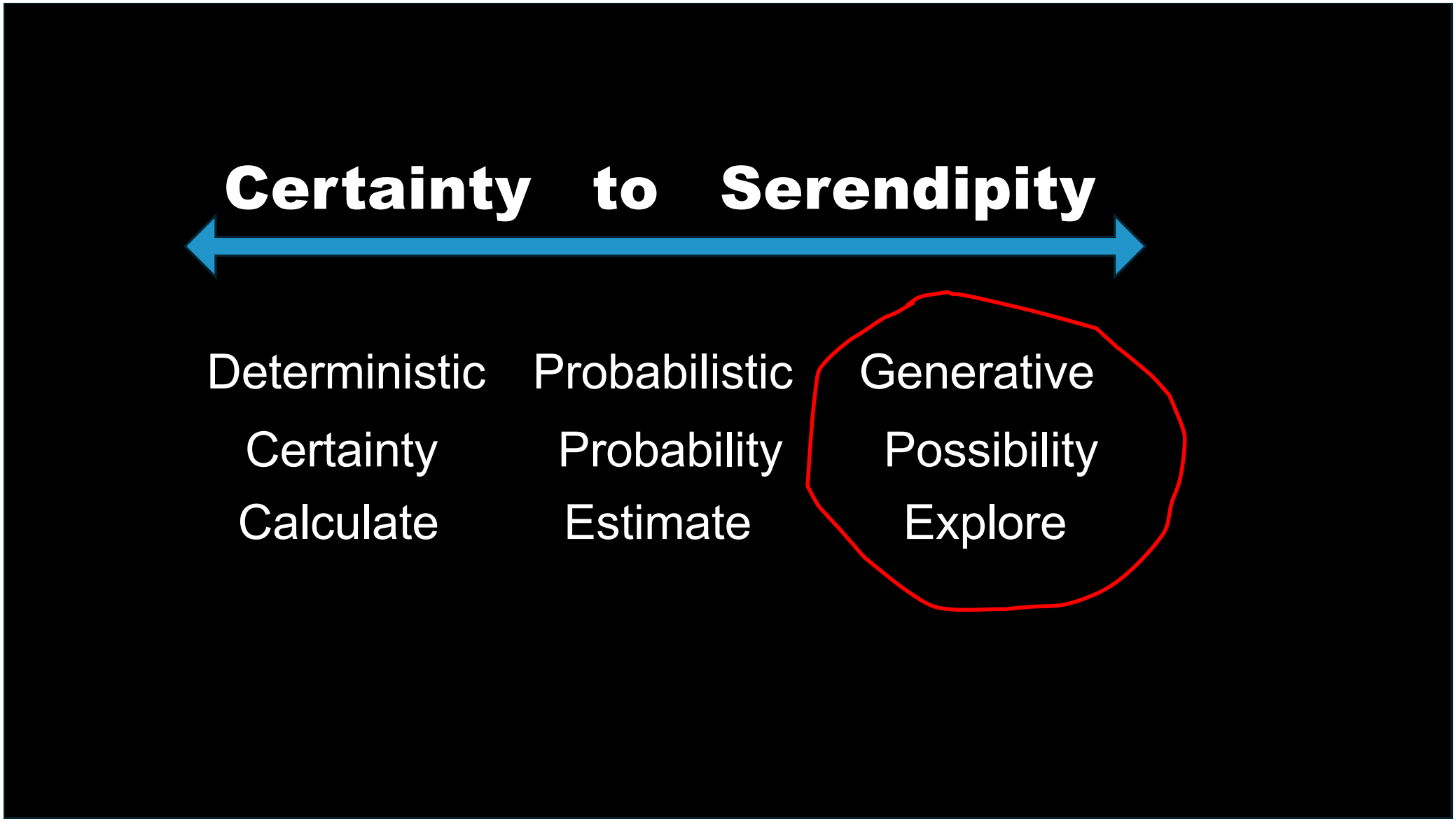
There is No Box – Hey ChatGPT:



Say I'm unavailable for 30 days
Using documented workflows
- What decisions stall?
- What is stuck on my desk?
- What authority rests solely with me?

Produce a delegation plan that makes my absence uneventful

Oh – and for succession planning


Certainty to Serendipity
Deterministic
Probabilistic
Generative
Certainty
Probability
Possibility
Calculate
Estimate
Explore

Certainty is for avoiding failure
Probability is for managing risk
Uncertainty is for creating value

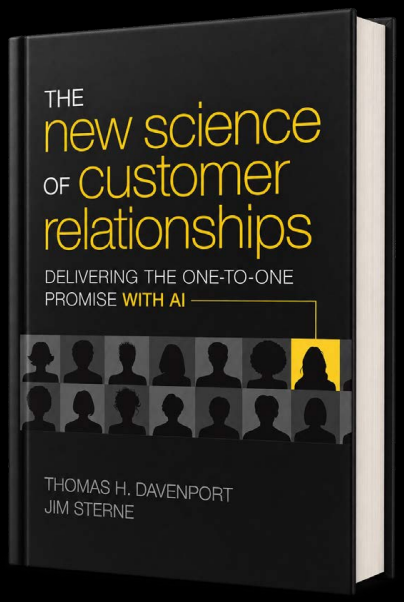
From enhanced automation to advanced imagination

Limitless –	What if?
Limiting –	But what about…?
Unorthodox –	There is no box

Ask Better Questions

Best Questions
Best Vision
Best Strategy
Best Data
Best Algorithm
Best Technology

Ask Better Questions



The one with the
best questions wins



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TRUST, VERIFY, LET IT FLY
SURFING THE CERTAINTY TO SERENDIPITY SPECTRUM



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THANK YOU! WE APPRECIATE YOUR SESSION FEEDBACK.

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